

Reading order under stress

Two columns, a merged table header, code, a figure, and a footnote must survive conversion into a reflowable book.

1. Input sequence

The copper marker starts the left column.
Read every left-column block before moving to the right column. A soft line break is not a new paragraph. The key has three steps:

1. Capture the source characters.
2. Preserve the code indentation.
3. Keep the footnote reference [1].

Listing 1. XML-safe output

```
def escape(value):  
    if value < 0:  
        return "<none>"  
    return f"{value}&ok"
```

Literal tags <book> and ampersands & remain text.

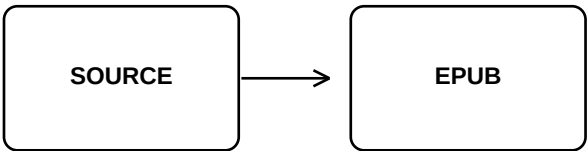
The goldfinch marker ends the left column.

2. Output sequence

The violet marker starts the right column.
The table has a header spanning three cells.
Its numeric values must stay in their rows.
Then the diagram follows the table.

Merged measurement header		
Item	Input	Output
alpha	2	4
beta	5	25

Figure 1. Two stages in reading order



The indigo marker ends the right column.

[1] This note belongs to the list, not to the page furniture.